are not family-controlled. The BJP, which was way behind other major political parties in giving tickets to women in the early 2000s, drastically changed its strategies and overtook them all by 2019 (see Table 17.1). The party's increase of women candidates served as an important signal. As the BJP became more established as the party of upward social mobility, it was also signalling to ambitious women looking for political careers that its doors were open.

Five smaller parties fielded a higher proportion of women than the BJP in 2019. These included Maharashtra's Shiv Sena, more than 50 per cent of the candidates of which were female. West Bengal's Trinamool Congress (37 per cent), Odisha's Biju Janata Dal (33.3 per cent) and Delhi's AAP (15 per cent) also embraced a more gender-equal candidature. However, these parties were all regional forces, each with a narrow geographic base. At the national level, the BJP's real comparison was with the Congress, and under Modi and Shah, the BJP drew level with its rival on this register. Interestingly, the BJP was also more accommodative of women candidates than the CPI (8.2 per cent women candidates) and only marginally lesser than the CPI(M) (14.5 per cent).

The female turn of the Shiva Sena, which competed for the same Hindu nationalist vote as the BJP in Maharashtra, has a long history. The gender studies scholar Sikata Banerjee,[75] the activist Teesta Setalvad[76] and the women's rights lawyer Flavia Agnes[77] have shown how, from the 1990s onwards, the Shiv Sena started focusing on women's issues and mobilising large numbers of women more successfully than liberal women's groups, raising vexing questions about gender and the Hindu cultural Right.[78] The Trinamool Congress, led by the woman satrap Mamata Banerjee, and BJD, led by India's longest-serving chief minister, Naveen Patnaik, both embraced far greater gender representation. Yet, these parties remained the exceptions. Across India, other regional political outfits, including the Dravidian parties (DMK and AIADMK), the Telugu parties (TDP and YSR-Congress) and the Dalit party, BSP, all gave less representation to women than the BJP did (see Table 17.1).

The BJP's woman-candidate share fell well short of the 33 per cent target of the long-debated Women's Reservation Bill, which is